

fridayReview

THE HINDU

In revival mode

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RAY IN A NEW LIGHT

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Bharathi Prathap

It was a quarter century ago that I began my journey with Lalithji, who opened up a whole new world for me. Music had been a hobby until then, but the moment she held my hand and led me into the depths of this vast ocean through her intensive *taalim*, it became my calling.

Lalithji was an institution in herself, with abundant knowledge and remarkable clarity on every aspect of music. Every class was an experience. She would make each raag emerge like a beautiful painting – bold in its strokes yet delicate in its hues – offering a vivid sense of the Agra *gayaki* she so cherished and took pride in.

“The throw of the voice,” she would say, “should have a three-dimensional effect, with emotions that touch the listener, only then will there be a spark in your singing.” Always supportive and encouraging, she consistently emphasised open-throated singing, one of the defining attributes of the Agra *gayaki*.

“I will teach you, but I don't take any *gurudakshina*. You should practise and sing well, that will be a tribute to my gurus,” she said before accepting me as her disciple; those words continue to ring in my ears.

It was in 2000 that Lalithji moved to Bengaluru with her husband, Jayavanth Rao. At the peak of her performing career, she lost her voice due to sinusitis. She also became selective about accepting students. Fortunately, I was part of a small group of sishyas who were not only taught but also cared for by Lalithji and Jayavanthji.

“Close the book,” she would say whenever we referred to the written bandish. “Repeat it a hundred and eight times so that you will never forget it. Your creative mind will not be available to you if you keep referring to the book.”

It was a great learning experience to travel with her for concerts and lec-dems. Her remarkable stage presence, rapport with the accompanying artistes, respect for the organisers and instant connect with the audience made it all memorable.

Punctuality meant a lot to her. Lalithji and Jayavanthji organised concerts in memory of her guru, Ustad Khadim Hussain Khan, in Bengaluru and ensured that the event began on time, even if there were only 10 or 15 people in the audience. Knowing this, audiences would arrive early. A perfectionist that she was, everything needed for the venue was packed immaculately – home-made herbal tea for the artistes, hot water, cups, biscuits, a lamp, oil, wicks, matchboxes and trays. Artistes coming from other cities would be lovingly hosted at their house.

Lalithji would also organise baithaks and lec-dems. We, her students, have had the good fortune of listening to the likes of Pt. SCR Bhat, Pt. Dinkar Kaikini, vidushi Neela Bhagwat, vidushi Meera Savoor and Pt. Ulhas Kashalkar.

1942 - 2026

Lalith J. Rao, who passed away recently, carried forward the Agra *gayaki* by training generations of disciples

In a class of her own



It is hard to find a guru who never missed being part of important occasions in our lives, visited us when we were unwell and even shared her room to ensure our comfort during trips. Beyond music, what we imbibed from her were the values of humility, honesty and affection. You could never separate the artiste from the fine human being she was – and that, I feel, is the greatest takeaway for us in today's times.

Our journey of learning under her was a path studded with precious gems, with a series of brilliant thematic presentations that she conceived and directed such as ‘Bhairav to Bhairavi’, ‘Raag rang samay yatra’, ‘Agra gharana ek vatavriksh’, ‘Panchrangi raagon ka

ek guldasta’, ‘Naman sajan piya’ on Ustad Khadim Hussain Khan, ‘Namananjali (for Pt. SCR Bhat's centenary) and ‘Guru Smarananjali’ (for Pt. Rama Rao V Naik's centenary).

When working on these presentations, she would always be open to ideas from anyone, and if that was incorporated, she would never miss to acknowledge that person in public. Her sole aim was to constantly enhance the quality of the productions.

Each of these presentations featured her evocative narration, interspersed with our renditions of khayal, dhrupad, dhamar, thumri, tarana, dadra, hori and kajri – in solos, duets and chorus. They required extensive rehearsals, for

which she would bring us together with enthusiasm. After every such session, her dining table would be laid out with a generous spread.

Ustad Khadim Hussain Khan saab was remembered in almost every other class, and Jayavanthji would often join in, sharing anecdotes in his inimitable style. At times, she would grow emotional while recalling her guru.

Like Khan saab, who encouraged her to attend concerts of both young and established artistes, she would also generously share live



Keeper of a legacy (Clockwise from far left) Lalith J. Rao; with her disciples at a concert; and an illustration of her guru Ustad Khadim Hussain Khan. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Dedicated archivist

Lalith J. Rao was a meticulous documenter, who readily engaged with institutions interested in preserving the Agra gharana tradition. Her archival work included projects with the Ford Foundation at the ITC Sangeet Research Academy, the Ethnomusicology Department at the University of Washington, Ahmedabad-based Rukvipa Trust and the National Centre for the Performing Arts.

To continue the tradition of archiving, the exponent encouraged her students to record several prakars of raags such as Bihag, Kanhada and Nat, along with their compositions and elaborations in the authentic Agra style. This included defining aspects of the gharana such as layakari, nom-tom alap, bol-bant, bol-banav, bol-taan and jod-taan. Her project for AIR, Raagantaranga, was a 13-episode series that explored four samaprakriti raags in each episode.

recordings of renowned musicians from different gharanas for us to imbibe and incorporate into our singing. This is how each of us developed an individual style, rooted firmly in the Agra *gayaki* that Lalithji taught us, without becoming mere replicas of her.

While we were blissfully immersed in this journey, little did we realise that she was moulding us into performing artistes. And when we got opportunities to perform on stage, seeing Lalithji and Jayavanthji seated in the front row, we felt reassured and drew immense strength to give our best.

The Agra-Atrauli gharana has a huge repertoire of raags and compositions. Through her teaching, she made us realise the depth and vastness of this hallowed tradition.

Even in her last days, she remained immersed in music. She would listen to recordings of various raags from her vast collection and make notes, highlighting aspects she felt we could imbibe. Such was her dedication. “Come and sing so that I may be distracted from the discomfort of my illness,” she would say.

We cherish and treasure every moment spent with our guru. She continues to live on in every note we sing and in the resonant strings of our tanpura.

A diligent student, a fabulous performer, a great guru, a loving wife, a caring mother and grandmother, and a friend, philosopher and guide to many – Lalithji embodied each role with grace, love and perfection. She will remain our enduring role model.

As her blessed disciples, spread across different parts of the world – Manohar Patwardhan, Susheela Mehta, Tara Kini, Vir Das Mahapatra, Lalitha Ramesh, Shanti Subbaraman, Niketa Kanitkar, Kailash Kulkarni, Pratima Bellave Ganesh, Deepa Hattangadi Karnad, Mallika Kilpadi, Vandana Pandit and Nishant Panicker – we will continue to do our bit, with sincerity and dedication, to uphold and spread the grandeur of the Agra *gayaki*.

The writer is a senior disciple of the legendary musician.



CULTUREBRIEFS

Back to old sabhas

Sumanasa Foundation has launched Sabhas-Live, an initiative to revive monthly concerts at older sabhas by providing funding, logistical and curatorial support. With efforts from senior mridangist Poongulam Subramaniam, the Foundation has reached out to various sabhas across Chennai for this initiative.

Currently, five sabhas have joined the initiative – Adambakkam Saphthaswaralaya, Gandharva Gana Sabha (Ambattur), Perambur Sangeetha Sabha, Sri Krishna Fine Arts (Nanganallur) and Sri Sadguru Sangeetha Sabha (Pammal) have joined the initiative. Each sabha will host six concerts,



curated by the Foundation annually, and continue with its own programming for the remaining months. Senior artistes have also come on board to support and perform.

The curtains go up on June 13 with N. Vijay Siva's concert at Adambakkam Saphthaswaralaya. He will be accompanied by Swaminathan S., Mullaivasal

G. Chandramouli, N. Manoj Siva and Anirudh Athreya. On June 27, Perambur Sangeetha Sabha will feature a concert by Amritha Murali, who will be accompanied by L. Ramakrishnan and N.C. Bharadwaj at Sri Ranga Hall. On June 28, a concert by Bharat Sundar with L. Ramakrishnan, Praveen Sparsh and Anirudh Athreya will be held at Gandharva Gana Sabha, Ambattur.

“The idea is to bring suburban sabhas back into the spotlight by hosting concerts of well-known artistes throughout the year. Concert culture should not remain confined to December or to a few central venues – rasikas in the suburbs deserve regular access to quality Carnatic kutchcheris,” says Carnatic musician T.M. Krishna.

The concerts will continue in July at Sri Krishna Fine Arts, Gandharva Gana Sabha, and Sri Sadguru Sangeetha Sabha. Updates and details will be shared on Sumanasa's social media handles.

Aaha! streams on

Aaha! Festival 2026 has entered its third week with a steady rhythm of performances streamed on AVALI.video. Conceived by Aravinth Kumarasamy, artistic director of the Singapore-based Apsaras Dance Company, in collaboration with *The Hindu*, the festival brings together emerging and established dancers in a digital celebration of classical artistry.

Launched on June 1, the inaugural week featured performances by Priyadarsini Govind and The Dhananjayans; while the second week featured Padma Subrahmanyam,

Rama Vaidyanathan, Hema Rajagopalan and a few more artistes, who have performed under Trailblazers, Rising Stars and Ensemble categories. The recordings will be available for viewing.

The third week will unfold with dance recitals by Anjana Anand on June 15 and Lakshmi Vishwanathan (archival footage) and Meenakshi Srinivasan on June 17. The Trailblazer section, for the said days, will showcase Mohanapriyan Thavarajah and Parshwanath Upadhye; while the ‘Rising Stars’ segment will present Aishwarya Ananth, Arthami Siva-Kuruvinth, Nithiyasree Nadeson and Gowri Sagar and will conclude with Kavya Muralidharan and ensemble.





Aishwarya Raghunathan

Among the many compositional legacies rescued from the margins of music history are the kritis by Brahmasri Ramaswamy Sivan and his brother, Maha Vaidyanatha Sivan, which are concise versions of Kacchiyappa Sivacharya's *Kandapuranam* verses. The Sivan Brothers, who lived and composed in the 19th century, were musicians of exceptional learning. Fluent in Tamil, Sanskrit and Telugu, they were also renowned for their literary scholarship. Both adopted 'Guhadasa' as their mudra, composing extensively across devotional and literary themes. Only a small portion of the kritis, one of the most significant works of the Sivan Brothers, survive – with around 40 of them published by Annamalai University.

These 40 songs formed the basis of the Sri Guhadasa Trust's thematic concert series, presented annually in honour of Maha Vaidyanatha Sivan. A five-part session that began at the 178th jayanti, concluded at the 182nd celebrated recently at the Arkay Convention Centre. On the occasion, the final seven kritis were performed by Bhavya Hari, Vidya Kalyanaraman and Brindha Manickavasakan, who were accompanied by Ananthakrishnan on the violin, Guru Ragavendra on the mridangam and Trichy K.

Call of the classics

Three women vocalists presented seven of the surviving Kandapuranam kritis at Sri Guhadasa Trust's Maha Vaidyanatha Sivan annual concert series

Murali on the ghatam.

The programme began with two songs outside of the *Kandapuranam* series composed by the Sivan Brothers. Brindha sang 'Athi mugathavan padam' in raga Janaranjani, set to Adi tisra gathi, composed by Venkatraman belonging to the lineage of the Sivan Brothers. This was preceded by Kacchiyappa Sivacharya's *Kandapuranam* cheyyul virutham 'Mann ulaginil'. In fact, all the virtham rendered by the vocalists were Sivacharya's compositions. Bhavya Hari followed with phalasruti virutham 'En nayagan' in Bilahari, leading into 'Mal maruganai ninaindiru', a Mel kala thani paadal, composed by Ramaswamy Sivan.

Then began the *Kandapuranam* kritis. The first, sung by Vidya was 'Indha

porutkalukul', introduced by the virutham 'Aadai thol' moving between ragas such as Anandabhairavi and Mohanam for its two halves. The virutham described how Shiva, disguised as an old man, teasingly lists his own supposed inadequacies to test Parvathi's resolve to marry him – from his graveyard abode and tiger-skin attire to erukku and umathai flowers, skulls, bones, snakes, poison, and an army of bhoothams – carried a literary precision that found an equal in the kriti that followed, whose clarity of meaning matched its beauty of expression. The violin traced a full arc across both ragas, and the vocalists sang the kalpanaswaras together. Brindha then sang 'Avatharithare' in Surutti and Chapu tala, a virutham from the Asura Kanda in which the devaguru bows to

Tiruchendur Muruga and narrates the origins of the asuras, preceded by the virutham 'Thandayum madanai'; the subsequent virutham by Bhavya, from the Yuddha Kanda – 'Pannuginradhu en' split between Purvikalyani and Khamas, with the violin playing one phrase in each raga, it seamlessly led to the kriti, 'Un karuthedhu sollada' in Khamas was also sung by Bhavya.

Vidya followed it up with the virutham 'Pudayura vananginar' in Varali, from the Deva Kanda, followed by the kriti, 'Indraniyum vandhu' in Shankarabaranam – its pretext goes by, when Indra was pleased and happy at Muruga's victory, Indra decides to offer his daughter Devayanai in marriage to Muruga at Tiruparankundram, he sends

a messenger to call Indrani, his wife along with their daughter. Then Indrani along with Devayanai arrives on Airavata from Mount Meru to the temple town.

The Daksha Kanda formed the core of the thematic presentation. Here, the devaguru narrated the story of Daksha to Jayantha, Indra's son; Brindha sang the virutham, 'Enbu neerodu kazhiyodu' in Hamir Kalyani and Dhanyasi – the violin remarkable throughout – before the kriti 'Igazhchiyo pugazhchiyo', its kalpanaswaras sung in 'Magizhchiyai marai', all three vocalists performing a neat full circle. The tani avartanam that followed was precise – bold mridangam strokes, the ghatam and mridangam interweaving cleanly end to end, the small chatusram-tisram mix in the mohara provided a moment of excitement.

Bhavya moved on to Valli Ammai avatharam segment of the concert with the virutham 'Emathin vadivam sarndha' followed by the kriti, 'Mogham niraindhane' in Abhogi. The concluding kriti of the series was rendered Vidya, who opened with the 'Mullai kuravar' virutham in Sahana before taking up the kriti, 'Tirumagal valarndale'. With the Maha Vaidyanatha Sivan mangalam, composed by Swetha (belonging to the Sivan Brothers' lineage), the five-year series came to a close.

A delightful tangle

Karpanai Kuthirai's Tamil play, *Chikku Bukku Kalyanam*, had the audience in splits with its comical chaos



Suganthy Krishnamachari

All the action in Karpanai Kuthirai's *Chikku Bukku Kalyanam* (written and directed by Vedarun Rajkumar) takes place on a train. The play was staged as part of Krishna Gana Sabha's summer drama festival. The story revolves around a hopelessly romantic girl – Ananya (portrayed by Subhiksha Sridharan) – who wants an unusual wedding venue and is travelling to marry her boyfriend at a railway station. She is also happy about her father's opposition to her choice, as she believes – what is a romance without parental disapproval? Ananya's father engages Mathew to spy on his daughter. Mathew, who is busy, requests his friend Balaji, a reformed pickpocket, to take his place on the train.

Two siblings – Kuntalakesi (Preeti Krishnan) and Manimekalai (Rini Chitra Kannan) – are also travelling in the same compartment as Ananya, albeit without tickets. Kuntalakesi is averse to what she sees as the superficial romance of the modern

world. Balaji, impersonating Mathew, is smitten by Manimekalai's charms. A comedy of errors unfolds inside the compartment. The journey is a riot of mistaken identities.

The ticket inspector, Valayapathi, is not only dim-witted, but does not realise he is. The sisters outwit him with their rapid, non-stop chatter. Raghavan was outstanding as Valayapathi and one couldn't help chuckling at Valayapathi's exaggerated self-confidence.

Mathew/Balaji pretends to throw up or put on a pair of shades to disguise himself, whenever he is on the verge of being exposed.

Paramesh's acting as Mathew/Balaji was the comedic *tour de force* of the play. *Chikku Bukku Kalyanam* was a journey which unleashed some delightful madness on stage. There was such a labyrinth of crossed wires in the play that it could easily have left the audience confused. But Vedarun Rajkumar navigated the tricky situations with ease, skillfully unspooling the tangled web he had created, without once losing his humorous touch.

Suganthy Krishnamachari

Archaeologist and epigraphist S. Rajavelu has spent a lifetime studying the past through fractured stones and fading scripts, rescuing it from silence. He has discovered and copied more than 1,565 inscriptions. Over the years, he has written nearly 1,500 articles for the Tamil Encyclopaedia and authored more than 100 research papers, making a sustained attempt to connect disparate historical strands. A strong advocate of the scientific dating of the Tamil (Tamil-Brahmi) script, Rajavelu argued that it may predate Ashokan Brahmi. During his tenure with the ASI, his study of onshore and offshore remains at Mamallapuram added fresh evidence to discussions around the legendary Seven Pagodas. In recognition of his research in many areas, a felicitation volume, which has articles by many epigraphists and archaeologists, was released in April this year. The volume was edited by eminent epigraphist Y. Subbarayalu. After the event, Rajavelu reflected on the milestones that have shaped his long and exacting engagement with history.

In 2004, Rajavelu found an inscription, engraved on a boulder, near the Tiger Cave at Saluvankuppam, a hamlet of Mamallapuram. The inscription, dated to the fourth regnal year of Rashtrakuta king Krishna III (939 to 967 CE), records a land grant to a Subrahmanya temple in Tiruvilichil village (old name of Saluvankuppam). "Usually, an inscription recording a donation is located in the vicinity of the land donated, or near the temple receiving the donation. In this case, Saluvankuppam could not have been donated land, because no one would have donated infertile, coastal land to a temple. That meant there must have been a Subrahmanya temple there," says Rajavelu. Further exploring the area, he found a mound near the inscription and some remnants of a temple at the surface level. The Archaeological Survey of India, Chennai Circle, was



HISTORY ETCHED IN STONE



informed, and they carried out excavations, in which Rajavelu participated. To his surprise, he found a ruined Pallava stone structure, predating Krishna III.

Digging deeper, he found remnants of a brick temple, on top of which the Pallava structure had been built. "The bricks were similar in size to those found in Arikamedu, Kaveripoompatinam, Uraiyur, Mangulam and Keezhadi. There were 21 rows of bricks," says Rajavelu. A terracotta plaque of the Sangam period was found, which showed five women holding hands and dancing kuravai koothu. The plaque confirmed that there was a Murugan temple in Saluvankuppam during the Sangam period. So far, this is the only Sangam-era temple unearthed in a coastal area.

Manimekalai says that a deluge submerged Kaveripoompatinam. This sea surge around the 6th century CE must have affected the entire East coast, submerging the

Saluvankuppam temple also. "From the inscriptions one can infer that the stone temple was built in the time of Nandivarman II (731-796 CE) and received donations from succeeding Pallava kings – Kampavarman and Nripatungavarman. From the inscriptions of Kampavarman we learn that women from Manayil (near Thiruvallur) came to this temple to conduct festivals. If people came from that far, then the Subrahmanya temple must have been popular in the Pallava period. An inscription of Kulottunga III (1178 to 1218 CE) shows that the temple continued to be worshipped even when Chola power was on the wane," explains Rajavelu.

Rajavelu's focused search helped him identify a Rashtrakuta temple. Rashtrakuta king Krishna III marched against the Cholas and set up a military camp in Melpadi, near Vellore. Krishna's Karhad copper plates mention that he built three

temples in Tamil Nadu – Kaalapriyam, Gandamarthandam and Krishneshwaram. At the Sundaravarada Perumal temple in Kaveripakkam, an inscription dated to the 6th regnal year of Sundara Chola, records that Kumara Chetti's son Sampakkam, who was associated with the Kaalapriya market, located in the city of Kirthimarthandam, donated 90 sheep to the Kaalapriyadeva temple. On this basis, some scholars concluded that the Rashtrakuta temple must have been built in Kaveripakkam. But since no such temple was found there, Rajavelu began to look for the temple in places nearby.

In Tirumalaicheri, five kms from Walajah, on the northern bank of the Palar, he found a ruined temple. A Kannada inscription here, which talks of a donation to the Kaalapriya temple, and about changes in the taxation system in Tondai Nadu, confirmed that this was the Kaalapriya temple built by Krishna,

A slice of the past (From left) A view of the Murugan temple in Saluvankuppam after excavation; S. Rajavelu (standing right) with T. Satyamurthy, ASI (sitting left) reading an inscription at the Saluvankuppam excavation; and the Kaalapriyadevar temple at Tirumalaicheri, built by Krishna III on the eve of his victory at Takkolam. PHOTOS COURTESY: ASI AND S. RAJAVELU



Archaeologist and epigraphist S. Rajavelu on how he used inscriptions to unearth ancient sites across Tamil Nadu



in a city called Kirtimarthandam Kaalapriyam, established by him. Although the temple was reconstructed in Raja Raja I's period, many portions of the earlier temple were retained.

A damaged five-foot-tall Mahesha idol with five heads and ten hands, discovered in a sugarcane field near the Tirumalaicheri temple, provides

further proof of the Rashtrakuta origin of the temple. "This Mahesha was similar to the one in Ellora, which is also of the Rashtrakuta period," says Rajavelu. He told the villagers to guard the invaluable idol. A few months later, when he returned to Tirumalaicheri, he found that the village elders had sold the idol, hoping to restore the temple with the money. "Since payment had been made by cheque, the buyer could be traced, and a case was registered against him by the Idol Wing. When the case came up in court, the prosecution did not bring in experts who knew the significance and rarity of the sculpture. The case was lost, and the idol went back to the buyer. It has never been seen nor heard of again. Only a picture taken by me survives," says Rajavelu, who mentions another temple in Sathambakkam, three kilometres from Tirumalaicheri. "There were no inscriptions, but it had Rashtrakuta features. This could be one of the other two temples built by Krishna."

Rajavelu's work shows that even a stone will speak, if you know how to listen to it.

Salvaged instruments find new life in Joydeep Mukherjee's house museum

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The Senia Shahjahanpur gharana, pivotal to the evolution of the modern sarod, symbolises how Indian classical music has bridged geographical barriers. It traces its roots to Miyan Tansen from whose lineage the ‘Senia’ tradition emerges. It gained a distinct identity when Ustad Murad Ali Khan moved from his ancestral home in Gwalior to Shahjahanpur, resulting in a style that blended Senia dhrupad aesthetics with regional influences. This legacy continued through Ustad Mohamed Ameer Khan, who preserved the contemplative character of the gharana’s music during a time of rapid cultural change. Under him, the gharana flourished through collaborations with Islamic court musicians and Bengal’s emerging intelligentsia, aided by its accomplished Hindu disciples. Among them was Pt. Radhika Mohan Maitra, who refined the sarod’s design and documented the gharana’s vast repertoire, while his shishya Pt. Buddhadeb Dasgupta, an engineer, brought mathematical precision, clarity and raga purity. Joydeep Mukherjee, who trained from the age of four under Pt. Pranab Kumar Naha in the Maitra tradition,



Sound relics Joydeep Mukherjee with his collection; and (below) a 1970 sitar, a 1960 tanpura and the seni rabab. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT & JOYDEEP MUKHERJEE

From gharana to ghar

represents the contemporary phase of the Senia Shahjahanpur gharana. Noting the dominance of the sarod and sitar in the gharana, he turned to reviving lesser-known instruments, an effort that culminated in a personal museum of 30 instruments at his Bally Halt home in Howrah. “Our gharana is an offshoot of the early 19th century Gwalior-Bangash gharana. I began playing other instruments such as the sursingar, mohan veena, dilbahar and the Tanseni rabab to increase their visibility on the concert stage,” he says. Sarods belonging to exponents Murad Ali Khan, Abdullah Khan and Mohamed Ameer Khan from the 19th century, along with Pt. Maitra’s 1956 instrument, are among the exhibits exclusive to the Senia Shajahanpur gharana at the museum.

Also on display are the mohan veena, dilbahar and the nabadeepa – three instruments created by Pt. Radhika Mohan Maitra in 1948, 1956 and 1967. “Each instrument is more than just a block of wood. They have to be restored and kept in working condition for the future generations,” says Joydeep, a computer science engineer, who turned full-time musician in 2019 after a career in marketing. Many popular Indian instruments such as the violin, sarod, santoor and sitar have been shaped by musicians over time and adapted to produce their distinctive tonal qualities. “In the case of the sarod, for instance, Ustad Abdullah Khan devoted at least 60 years to innovation. Unfortunately, such sustained engagement is missing when it comes to older instruments, which possibly required a higher level of learning and

skill to play,” says Joydeep. To revive long-forgotten sounds, Joydeep has recreated several instruments using modern elements such as metallic strings, light wooden bodies and travel-friendly sizes and patented them as well. He designed the surveena, a blend of the mohan veena and the sur rabab, and is in the process of patenting it. “When recreating instruments from older templates, I focus on the hardware, design and, for contemporary use, integrated microphone system,” he adds. He holds the patents for seven instruments – sarod, sursingar, sur rabab, seni rabab, mohan veena, dilbahar and nabadeepa. “My engineering background helps me with the innovation and restoration while retaining the original sound. Patents give a legal protection to these rare instruments,” he shares. His instrument collection

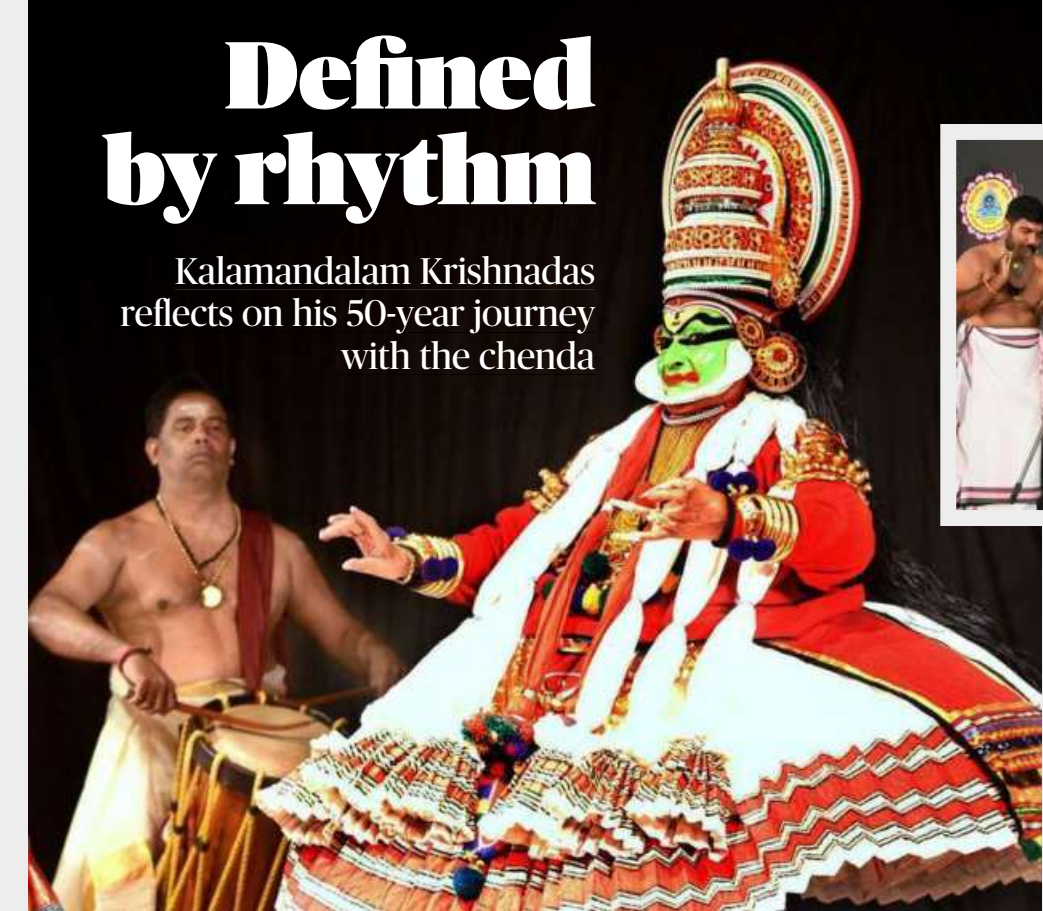
grew over the years as he travelled for concerts. “My gharana’s music has flourished in the northern part of the subcontinent – Peshawar, Lahore, Punjab, Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh, Darbhanga and parts of Bangladesh. Whenever I perform in historic cities such as Agra, Lucknow or Delhi, I try to visit old music shops. I also salvaged some discarded string instruments from a demolished building in Darbhanga, where my gharana once had a strong presence in the erstwhile royal court. One man’s trash is another’s treasure,” he laughs. Joydeep’s personally funded museum, located on the ground floor of his residence in Kolkata, is clearly a labour of love. A few of the unusual exhibits include a bill from 1948 for a mohan veena costing ₹51, written in Bengali, and a plectrum of Baba Alauddin Khan, gifted to Pt. Radhika Mohan Maitra in 1937 at Allahabad. “The Gwalior-Bangash gharana of Ustad Hafiz Ali Khan, the Maihar gharana of Baba Alauddin Khan, and the Senia-Shajahanpur gharana of Pt. Radhika Mohan Maitra are the three leading traditions in sarod music. Gwalior and Maihar have showcased their gharanas through museums; I hope to spotlight the Senia Shajahanpur gharana through my museum,” he says.

Percussive pathways Kalamandalam Krishnadas with Kalamandalam Gopi. (Below) With his daughter Margi Rahifha. PHOTOS COURTESY: R. JAYARAM AND HAREESH NAMPOOTHIRI



tolerable compared to Pallassana. “At home, we were woken at 3.30 a.m. for chenda exercises. After school, seniors would make us practice till midnight. At Kalamandalam, we could sleep better. Yet, the dawn-drill was followed by errands,” he says. When he moved to the senior level, Krishnadas began playing for Kathakali students at chollyiyattam classrooms, where exponents such as Ramankutty Nair, Padmanabhan Nair and Gopi taught. “This intensive training helped me when I joined Margi as an apprentice. Yet, the Mankulam style at Margi differed from the Chengannur idiom taught at the Kalamandalam’s southern wing,” he says. By the early 1990s, Krishnadas was fairly established. He was further mentored by Thiruvananthapuram’s chenda masters such as

Raman Namboothiri and Sadanam Vasudevan. The iconic actor Kalamandalam Krishnan Nair made Krishnadas a part of his troupe for lecture-demonstrations, while Ramankutty Nair and Gopi guided him through finer nuances. As fellow percussionist Vellinezhi Anand observes, “Krishnadas is capable of conjuring surprises; his outcomes are sometimes unpredictable.” Krishnadas pre-plans certain rhythmic phrases and rehearses them. “My uncle continues to be my exemplar, but times have changed. The percussive pieces sound more ornamental; even the chenda’s timbre has altered significantly,” he says, also referring to his percussionist daughter, Margi Rahitha. “The founding principles cannot be diluted. I have been the sole chenda player for an entire night of Kathakali. You must wield total control over the momentum of a scene.”



Sreevalsan Thiyyadi

During his five-decade association with the chenda, Kalamandalam Krishnadas has played a pivotal role in redefining the percussive aesthetics of Kathakali. This, however, has not distanced him from his childhood bond with Kanyarkali, a folk and ritualistic dance-drama performed across temples in his native eastern Palakkad. Krishnadas has been living in Thiruvananthapuram for the past 40 years. The Margi

Academy, in the State capital, employed him soon after he completed his training in chenda at Kalamandalam in 1985. Ever since, Krishnadas has been a vital presence in the Kathakali circuits. Recently, he celebrated his 60th birthday in Margi, where he serves as the Principal. Krishnadas grew up playing the chenda for the night-long Kanyarkali. His uncle, Pallassana Chandra Mannadiyar (1925-99), a 20th-century Kathakali percussionist, was equally adept in Kanyarkali. In his prime, he taught Kathakali

chenda at Kalamandalam, around the time his 14-year-old nephew joined as a student. At Kalamandalam, Krishnadas, already familiar with the basics, trained under stalwarts such as Krishnankutty Poduval, Achunni Poduval and Varanasi Madhavan Namboothiri, in addition to Mannadiyar. Three months later, during Onam, he made his Kathakali chenda debut, performing for the invocatory purappad dance. The rigour at Kalamandalam was demanding, yet far more

CALENDAR



Vocal concert

Madhuradhvani, in association with Sahasraa Foundation, has organised the following concerts (June 12-16) at Arkay Convention Centre, Mylapore. Schedule: Today, 6.15 p.m.: Deepika and Nandhika (vocal). June 13, 6.15 p.m.: R.P. Shravan. June 14, 6.15 p.m.: Bharat Narayan. June 15, 6.15 p.m.: Sreeranjane Kaushik. June 16, 6.15 p.m.: Padmashree Srinivasan.

Musical tribute

Sarvani Sangeetha Sabha Trust has organised Radha Bhaskar’s tribute concert, to mark the third remembrance day of Vasanta, co-founder of the Trust, on June 14, 6.15 p.m. at Ragasudha Hall, Luz, Mylapore.

Bharatanatyam solo

The Music Academy has organised Kshirja Govind’s Bharatanatyam performance as part of HCL concerts, today, 6 p.m. at the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall.

Dance debut

Bharata Kalanjali and Mrudani School of Performing arts will jointly present Arangetram utsav 2026 from June 12 to 14, 6 p.m. - 8.30 p.m., at The Spastics Society of Tamil Nadu, TEACH Auditorium, Taramani. Students of Anuradha Murali – Anoushka Bhakar (June 12), Yashasvi Vadlamani (June 13) and Poornema Ramasamy (June 14) will perform.

Bhajan competition

Bhakthaswaraa Bhajan Mandali, in association with Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Mylapore, invites applications from schools to participate in the 38th inter-school bhajan competition to be conducted in July. The preliminary rounds will be held on July 4 and 5 and the finals will be on July 12. Last date is June 30. For details, call 98416 67059.

Lecture series

Sri Kamakoti Bhaktha Samaj Trust celebrates the 12th year Sri Ramanavami utsavam from June 19 to 26 (7 p.m.) at Devi Academy Senior Secondary School, Valasarawakkam. The festival begins with Kadayanallur Rajagopal Das’ bhajan renditions today, 6.30 p.m. Tiruchi Kalyanaraman’s discourse (June 20-26) will be at 7 p.m.

Consecration

The jeernodharana ashtabandhana mahakumbabishekam of Sri Vijaya Ganapathy temple at Krishna Nagar, Ullagaram, will be performed on June 18, between 10.30 a.m. and 11.15 a.m. Preliminary rituals will begin from June 15. Mandalabishekam will take place from June 19 to August 5. Namasankirtanam, upanyasam and music concerts will form part of the festival.

Tamil play

Under auspices of Kartik Fine Arts, Mali’s Stage inaugurates its Tamil play Thoduvana Manidhargal today at Mylapore Fine Arts Club. Time: 6.30 p.m.

Journey of life

‘Aham Pravahini — I am the river and this is my journey’ — produced by Shobana Balachandra, will be staged on June 13 at 6 p.m. at the Kalakshetra Foundation. Co-produced by Preeti Anand, the production has music by Kalaimamani Embar S. Kannan. Tickets for the show are available on MDnD.

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PARAS

A CH-CE

An enduring ACT

Through his grand productions featuring elaborate sets, celebrated musicians and well-known actors, C. Cunniah transformed Tamil theatre into a vibrant visual experience

Karthik Bhatt

C. Cunniah was one of Tamil theatre’s greatest legends in the early decades of the 20th century. His productions were known for their grandeur, and he was considered a forerunner to the likes of Nawab Rajamanickam Pillai and R.S. Manohar in the mythological genre. A brief profile of this legend, compiled by T.C. Vadivelu Naicker, a noted theatre artiste and one of the pioneers of early Tamil cinema, was published in the drama book of Cunniah’s last magnum opus theatrical work, *Bhagavad Gita*. Cunniah was born in 1877 (though curiously, the Government of Tamil Nadu celebrated his birth centenary in 1973). His interest in studies was limited, for, his formal education lasted only till the fourth standard. Aware of the need to learn a craft with which he could earn a livelihood, his parents enrolled him in the Parur Thyagaraja Sastri Press on Govindappa Naicken Street in George Town, Chennai, where he learnt composing and became a Telugu compositor. He later

joined the government press and worked in the same capacity. The acting bug bit him around this time, when he started watching plays being performed by Subbaraya Achari, a noted theatre practitioner of those times. Deciding to become an actor, he quit his job and joined an entourage of performers led by Gopala Rayar on a year-long tour to Singapore. On his return, he joined a drama company run by Narayanaswamy Pillai as an actor at a monthly salary of ₹ 2. His association with the company lasted for nearly seven years, during which time he essayed a variety of small roles and soon started making a name for himself. Pursuing wider opportunities, Cunniah quit Narayanaswamy Pillai’s company and went to Rangoon, where he joined a drama company as a lead actor. The brief stint saw him gain recognition. On his return to Madras, he launched the Sri Krishna Vinodha Sabha, which went on to become one of the premier performing theatre companies in the early 1900s.



ILLUSTRATION: SAI

One of its earliest productions was *Sakunthala*, with Cunniah performing the role of Dushyanta. Spurred by its success, Cunniah embarked on a series of mega productions over the course of the next few years such as *Sampurna Ramayanam* (where he essayed six roles, including that of Kaikeyi and Surpanakha), *Kandirajan*, *Chandravali*, *Sathya Harischandra*, *Lankadhamam* and *Vasanthika* with the Royal Theatre at Salt Cotaurs as his base. Cunniah appointed noted comedy actor of those times, C.S. Samanna Iyer as the troupe’s manager and toured many places across South India, earning accolades from prominent personages such as the royal

family of Thanjavur. That Cunniah was greatly influenced by Parsi theatre’s production values is evidenced by the fact that he selected Ameer Ali of the New Albert Parsi Theatre Company as Krishna Vinodha Sabha’s music director. He also appointed Hussain Bakhsh, an artiste from Lahore, for a huge salary. He was in-charge of the troupe’s scenes and settings. Notable actors of the Krishna Vinodha Sabha included the likes of comedian K. Sarangapani, C.V.V. Pantulu and Maharajapuram Krishnamurthy. However, the prominent name of them all was S.G. Kittappa, who, along with his brothers formed a fruitful association with Cunniah. Kittappa’s musical genius propelled Krishna Vinodha Sabha to greater heights. Productions such as *Dasavatham* (said to

have been produced at a cost of more than a lakh) and *Krishna Leela* owed much of their success to Kittappa’s singing, which drew many classical musicians such as Kanchipuram Naina Pillai, Fiddle Govindaswamy Pillai, Marungapuri Gopalakrishna Iyer and Konnakkol Pakkiri Pillai to watch the plays. Interestingly, Cunniah travelled to Penang in 1926 and helped the renowned Ganesananda Dramatic Troupe of the Federated Malay States produce and stage *Dasavatham*. Mridangam exponent Pudukkottai Dakshinamurthy Pillai and dholak player Venu Chettiar were part of the Sabha’s music retinue. Cunniah was also an admirer of harikatha exponent C. Saraswathi Bai and once invited her to perform for his troupe and presented her with a gold cup. He was in awe of her ability to bring alive many deities through her expositions, a task which he remarked was undertaken by many together in his troupe. A staunch Vishnu-bhakta, Cunniah was especially devoted to the mystic-poet Andal (he even staged a play titled *Andal Thirukalyanam-Ramanuja Vaibhavam*) and donated a golden pot to the Srivilliputhur temple. He also donated liberally to other Vaishnavite shrines such as Thirukannapuram, Thirukannamangai, the Parthasarathy temple at Triplicane and the Ramanuja shrine at Sriperumbudur. Organisations such as the Ramakrishna Mission Students’ Home too benefited by his benevolence.

In 1930, Cunniah embarked on an ambitious project – to dramatise the Bhagavad Gita. It took over a year for the production to take shape, with Cunniah pouring his heart and soul into it. However, behind the scenes, a life of relentless activity was slowly starting to take its toll on Cunniah and he seemed to have had an inkling that it would be his last offering. He was supposed to have remarked to those around him that no matter what happened to him, the show must go on. It proved to be eerily prophetic, for he passed away at his residence, on Mint Street, on August 31, 1931, a week after the production’s inauguration. Chinnammal, his wife, led the troupe for a while before it was finally wound up. Unfortunately, Cunniah’s achievements remain a distant footnote in the annals of Tamil theatre.

CULTURE BRIEFS

Pivot on Pallavis

The annual Pallavi Darbar festival, jointly presented by Carnatica and Sri Parthasarathy Swami Sabha will be held from June 12 to 16 at Srinivasa Sastri Hall, Luz, Mylapore. The inauguration will be followed by an award function (5.15 p.m.) and Ramana Balachandhran’s veena recital at 6.15 p.m. Concerts to take place on June 13 are: 10.30 a.m.: Pallavi Jam - On the Spot Pallavi Potpourri - featuring Pathangi Brothers (vocal) and Charulatha Chandrasekhar (veena); 2 p.m.: Sruthi Ravali Manda (vocal); 3.30 p.m.: Swarathmika Srikanth (vocal); 5.15 p.m.: K.S. Vishnudev (vocal) and 7 p.m.: R. Suryaprakash (vocal). Concerts on June 14 begin with Jayashri Vaidyanathan’s vocal concert (9.15 a.m.) followed by that of Delhi P. Sunder Rajan (10.30 a.m.); Anirudh Subramaniam (2 p.m.); Spoorthi Rao (3.30 p.m.); Amrutha Venkatesh (5.15 p.m.); and Kunnakudi M. Balamurali Krishna (7 p.m.). The following is the list of artistes to perform on June 15: Deepika Venkatraman and Nandhika (3.30 p.m.); K. Gayatri (5.15 p.m.) and Bharat Sundar (7 p.m.). The festival concludes on June 16 with the vocal concerts by Shruthi Shankar Kumar (3.30 p.m.); Anahita and Apoorva (5.15 p.m.) and violin recital by Nagai R. Muralidharan and Badrinarayanan at 7 p.m.

Annual music festival

Sri Thyaga Brahma Gana Sabha celebrates Nadaswaram festival - 2026 from June 18 to 20 and Tamil Isai concert series from June 21 to 23 at Vani Mahal, T. Nagar. On the occasion, the ‘Vani Vadhya Kala Nipuna’ title will be presented to Nagaswaram vidwans Chinnamanur A. Vijay Karthikeyan and Idumbavanam V. Prakash Ilaiyaraj. The ‘Vani Laya Kala Nipuna’ title will be given to thavil vidwan Bengaluru P.M. Ranjith Vinayak. This will be followed by the nagaswaram recital of Vijay Karthikeyan and Prakash Ilaiyaraj’s at 7 p.m. June 19, 6.30 p.m.: T.P.N. Ramanathan and Pandamangalam P.G. Yuvaraj. June 20, 6.30 p.m.: Semponnarkoil S.R.G.S. Mohandas and thirumayilai K. Selvam. Music concerts to take place from June 21 to 23 at 6.30 p.m. are: Dr. R. Ganesh; Mahanyasree and R. Kashyap Mahesh.



A new shade of Ray

The exhibition *Faces and Facets; Satyajit Ray in Color* lends a new dimension to the legendary filmmaker

Neeta Lal

For generations, Satyajit Ray has lived in public memory in shades of black-and-white. The celebrated filmmaker appears in iconic portraits with his trademark spectacles, directing actors on set, smoking thoughtfully between takes or gazing into the distance with characteristic intensity. These images, etched in India’s cultural imagination, seem inseparable from the man himself. Yet, a remarkable exhibition at Delhi Art Gallery (DAG) is challenging that familiar image. *Faces and Facets; Satyajit Ray in Color*, on view till July 4, presents the filmmaker through a series of rarely-seen colour photographs by Nemai Ghosh, who documented Ray’s life and work for over two decades. The exhibition

offers something rare: a chance to encounter one of the world’s most-studied filmmakers anew. The exhibition is a collection of photographs by Ghosh, Ray’s trusted collaborator and principal still photographer. Beginning with *Goopy Gyne Bagha Byne* in 1968, Nemai documented the filmmaker with rare access, eventually creating an archive of thousands of images. Interestingly, photography was not Ghosh’s first calling. As a young man, he was immersed in theatre. His entry into photography was accidental. A friend who owed him ₹240 showed him a Canonette QL-16 camera that had been left behind in a taxi. Ghosh immediately asked for it in lieu of repayment – an act that altered the course of his life. On a trip to Burdwan with friends, he carried the camera to the set of Ray’s *Goopy Gyne Bagha Byne* and took several photographs with

no particular intention. Seeing them, art director Bansi Chandragupta took Ghosh to Ray, who was impressed by his photographic skills and invited him to join his unit in 1968 – beginning a collaboration that lasted until the filmmaker’s passing in 1992. What makes the images, at DAG, compelling is not just the fact that they are in colour, but the manner in which colour alters our perception of a personality. Suddenly, Ray feels less like a distant legend and more like a living, breathing artiste. The earthy tones of Ray’s clothing, **The exhibition is equally a tribute to Ghosh, whose photographs have become inseparable from the visual history of Ray’s career.**

Frozen in time Images from the exhibition. PHOTOS COURTESY: DAG

the warm light filtering into his workspace, the textures of books, papers and sketches scattered around him – all emerge differently. These photographs capture Ray in moments both public and personal – studying scripts, sketching storyboards, directing and conversing. They offer a glimpse into the creative environment from which some of cinema’s most enduring works emerged. The trust Ray had in Ghosh, is evident throughout the exhibition. The images feel unguarded and spontaneous. The exhibition is equally a tribute to Ghosh, whose photographs have become inseparable from the visual history of Ray’s career. Reflecting on the relationship years later, Ghosh wrote: “I followed him like his shadow. I was crazy about capturing him on my camera every moment.” Ghosh’s works have been exhibited extensively in India and overseas, and became part of the permanent collection of the National Gallery of Modern Art.

Stirring up an identity

Directed by Geetha Ilangoan, the Tamil microdrama *Kavithavum Kooraipalliyum* leaves a lasting impact

Kavitha Muralidharan

There is a moment in *Kavithavum Kooraipalliyum* that lingers long after the episode ends. The doorbell rings and Kavitha rushes to answer it – unkempt hair, ladle in hand and batter on her face. At the door, is her friend Jenny – elegant, confident and self-assured – visiting from the U.S. The contrast is almost cruel. The encounter reflects an uncomfortable question that women are rarely allowed to ask: What does it take to have a life of their own? That question sits at the heart of *Kavithavum Kooraipalliyum*, a series streaming on the recently launched Tamil microdrama platform – Kadhaishorts. Microdramas are in the spotlight. The format, which had its genesis in China before expanding to other markets, thrives on emotional intensity and quick storytelling. Revenge sagas, billionaire romances, secret heirs, family betrayals and miraculous second-chances dominate this narrative landscape. Women are often central to these narratives – usually as victims, saviours, avengers or romantic leads. But *Kavithavum Kooraipalliyum* chooses a different path. Kavitha is a homemaker who believes her family revolves around her. Then, an accident changes everything. A coma takes her out from the household for several days. During her absence, the family learns to adapt. When Kavitha wakes up, she is confronted by a harsh truth – the family can survive without her. For the first time in years, she begins to ask herself what she wants. The answer takes her back to music. A talented singer during her college years, Kavitha gave it up after marriage. Her journey eventually leads her to a stage, where she auditions for a singing competition. What is refreshing is that the series refuses to fall into yet another stereotype by showing Kavitha as the winner. She falters, learns slowly and stands on the stage. And that, in itself, is a victory. Director Geetha Ilangoan says the story emerged from observing how patriarchy keeps many women, particularly



homemakers, trapped in guilt. Over time, Geetha adds, women begin to see themselves solely through their relationships. That insight shapes the series’ central metaphor. The title references the story of a lizard that imagines it is holding up the entire roof. Only when it falls does it realise the roof can stand perfectly well without it. Music becomes central to that rediscovery. The two songs – written by lyricist Uma Devi – serve as emotional milestones in Kavitha’s journey. The first, ‘Naanthaane naanthaane’, belongs to a younger Kavitha who believes in herself. Geetha points to the line ‘Isai rani naanthaane’ (I am the queen of music) as particularly significant. Women are rarely encouraged to claim artistic excellence with such confidence. The second song, ‘Mele vaa’, arrives as Kavitha begins reclaiming her life. AniVee’s compositions lend emotional depth to a transformation that is ultimately internal rather than dramatic. Written by Kamali Panneerselvam and Geetha Ilangoan, the series benefits from creators who clearly understand the lives they are portraying. They encourage women to ask a simple question – What do you want?